THE TRUTH ABOUT FOOD, WEIGHT, AND RECOVERY

# BEYOND THE SCALE

A quick, compassionate guide to help you understand your relationship with food and body — and take your first step toward freedom.

BY ALYNNE DAVIS, LCMHC, EXPRESSIVE ARTS THERAPIST

# WELCOME

## Hi There!

If you've picked up this guide, you might be tired of feeling stuck in the same exhausting cycle with food and your body. Maybe you've tried dieting, cutting out sugar, or pushing yourself harder in the gym — and yet nothing feels "good enough."
I want you to know: you're not broken.

Your struggles with food aren't about willpower — they're a natural response to deprivation, stress, and mixed messages from our culture.

In the next few pages, I'll share truths about eating, weight, and recovery that most people never hear. My hope is that you'll walk away feeling more informed, more compassionate with yourself, and more hopeful about what's possible.

You don't have to figure this out alone. This guide is just your first step.

With Care,

Alynne Davis

## ABOUT ME

I'm Alynne Davis, a Licensed Professional Counselor and Expressive Arts Therapist specializing in eating disorders, ADHD, and trauma recovery.

With over a decade of experience, I help women, men and families break free from the exhausting cycle of food rules, body shame, and self-criticism. My approach blends science-backed strategies like CBT with creative, trauma-informed techniques to help you heal your relationship with food, reconnect with your body, and step into a more peaceful, confident life.

# SUGAR ADDICTION VS. EATING DISORDER

01

**What you've heard:**

"Sugar is addictive — it's just like a drug."

**The truth:**

While sugar can light up reward centers in the brain, this doesn't mean it's the same as a substance addiction. In fact, the restriction of certain foods — not the food itself — often fuels bingeing. When your body feels deprived, your brain ramps up cravings as a survival mechanism. **This isn't weakness — it's biology.**

Many people describe feeling addicted to sugar, but research does not support sugar addiction as a true substance addiction in the way drugs or alcohol are. Instead, these feelings are often rooted in cycles of restriction, deprivation, and guilt around food. When we restrict certain foods—especially those labeled as "bad"—it can intensify cravings and create a rebound effect, where we feel out of control once we finally eat them.

Rather than pathologizing the behavior as addiction, eating disorder treatment looks deeper: exploring trauma, unmet needs, self-critical parts, and emotional regulation. Recovery involves understanding these root causes and developing a more compassionate and flexible relationship with food.

**Key takeaway:**

If you've been restricting sugar and then find yourself "losing control" around it, it's not proof you're addicted — it's proof your body is trying to protect you.

# WHY LABELING FOOD IS DANGEROUS

02

When we label foods as “good” or “bad,” we attach morality to what we eat — and by extension, to ourselves.

- Eat “good” food? You feel virtuous.
- Eat “bad” food? You feel guilty or ashamed.

This black-and-white thinking is a major driver of disordered eating patterns and keeps you disconnected from your body’s natural cues. It can even make you more likely to overeat the “off-limits” foods when you finally allow them.

**When we assign moral value to food—calling it "good" or "bad"—we also tie our worth to eating a certain way.**
This fuels guilt when we eat the "bad" food and can lead to a restrict-binge-shame cycle. The brain fixates on what’s forbidden, increasing the desire for it. Think of it like a psychological red button — when we say “don’t touch,” it becomes all we can think about.

In contrast, when all foods are emotionally and physically allowed, the intensity around them often fades. This approach supports attunement to real hunger, satisfaction, and emotional needs, rather than cycles of control and guilt.

**Food neutrality** — seeing all foods as having a place in a balanced diet — helps remove the guilt/shame cycle. When you stop moralizing food, you can start making choices based on your actual needs, preferences, and how your body feels, not fear.

# WHAT THE BRAIN DOES WHEN FOOD IS RESTRICTED

03

Your brain's #1 job is to keep you alive — not to help you fit into a certain clothing size.

When food is restricted (intentionally or unintentionally), your body shifts into survival mode:

- Hunger cues become louder and more urgent.
- Thoughts about food become more frequent and obsessive.
- Energy is conserved by lowering motivation, movement, and mood.
- Reproductive hormones may decline to save energy.

**The brain perceives restriction as a survival threat.** The hypothalamus triggers intense hunger cues to ensure you seek out food. Hunger hormones shift: ghrelin increases (stimulating hunger), while leptin decreases (reducing satiety). The dopamine reward system heightens focus on "forbidden" foods, making them feel more desirable.

When this happens, the prefrontal cortex (your rational brain) takes a backseat while the survival brain dominates, leading to reactive or impulsive eating. This cycle is biological, not a failure of willpower. The more we restrict, the more the brain fights back through intense cravings and obsessive food thoughts.

This is why "just eating less" backfires — your brain will fight to restore balance. True recovery means consistently giving your body enough nourishment so your brain can stop sounding the alarm.

# BODY COMPOSITION VS. BMI (AND WHY **BMI** IS **BS**)

04

**BMI (Body Mass Index)** is an outdated formula created in the 1830s by a mathematician, not a medical doctor.

- It only uses height and weight — no information about muscle, bone, hydration, or fat distribution.
- It was never intended to measure individual health.
- It often misclassifies people and fuels harmful weight stigma.

**Why it's especially problematic in recovery:**

BMI says nothing about whether your body has restored muscle mass, improved energy, or regained hormonal balance. It reduces your health to a single number, which can be triggering and misleading.

**Body Composition** gives a more complete picture — looking at how much of your body is made of muscle, fat, bone, and water.

- Muscle mass supports metabolism, hormone production, and strength.
- Restoring lean tissue is critical after restriction or malnutrition.
- Function, energy, and quality of life matter more than a chart category.

**Bottom line:** Your worth and your health are not determined by BMI.

# WHY THE NUMBER ON THE SCALE KEEPS YOU STUCK

05

For many people struggling with food and body image, weighing becomes a safety behavior — a way to feel in control, manage anxiety, or "check" if things are okay. At first, it might feel harmless or even motivating. But over time, it quietly fuels the eating disorder cycle.

**Here's why:**

- It reinforces external validation. The scale teaches you to trust a number over your body's signals.
- It keeps you in an all-or-nothing mindset. If the number is lower, you might feel relief and restrict more. If it's higher, you might panic, restrict harder, or binge in defeat.
- It triggers shame and anxiety. Even tiny fluctuations (often just water, hormones, or digestion) can spiral into self-criticism and extreme behaviors.

In eating disorder treatment, weighing is seen as a maintaining factor — meaning it keeps the disorder alive by feeding obsessive thinking, reinforcing body dissatisfaction, and distracting from deeper emotional work.

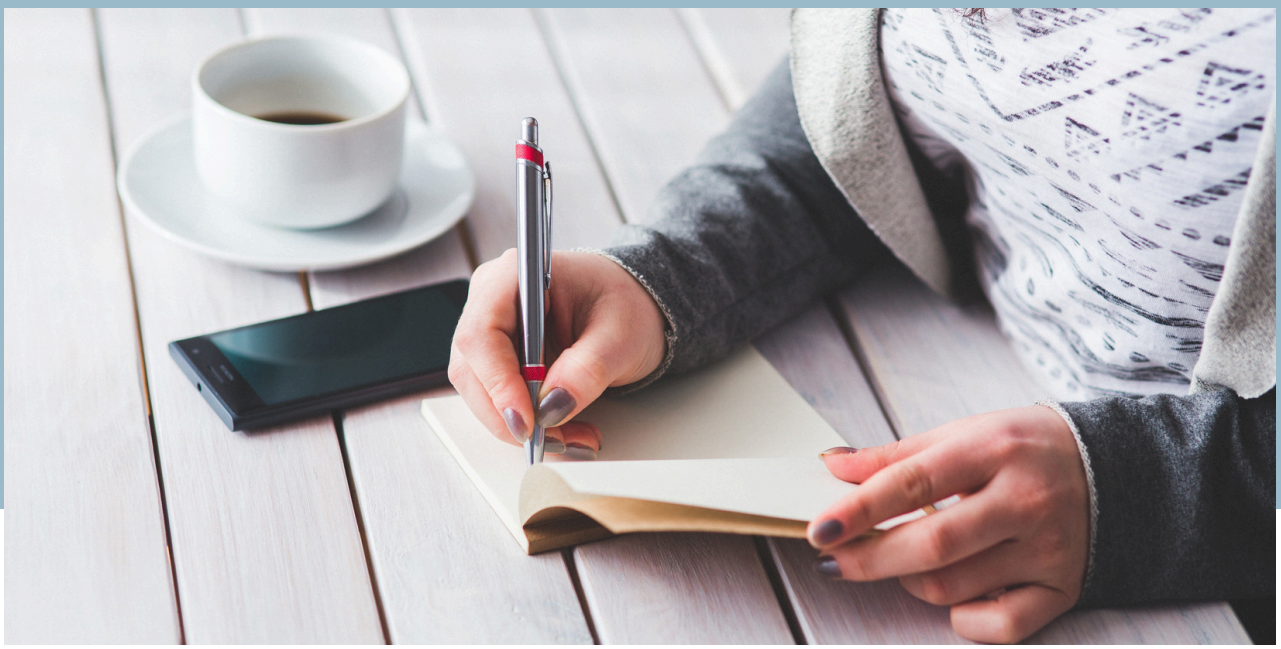
When you **stop using the scale as your "truth,"** you create space to:

- Tune in to hunger, fullness, and satisfaction.
- Notice improvements in energy, mood, and strength.
- Measure progress in terms of life lived — not pounds lost or gained.

The **truth** is, healing requires learning to live without the constant reassurance (or punishment) of that number. Freedom starts when you let your body guide you more than the scale does.

# QUICK REFLECTION

*Take a few moments to explore these questions. Write your answers in the space provided or in your own journal:*



01 When I label food as "bad," I usually...

02 One sign my body is underfed is...

03 If I could eat without guilt, I would...

04 One way I'd like to feel in my body is...

If this guide resonated with you, please know: you don't have to keep battling your body or trying to "fix" yourself. Recovery is not about restriction, punishment, or shrinking yourself — it's about reclaiming your energy, freedom, and self-trust.

**You deserve a life beyond the scale.**

Allynne Davis

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